MILITARY SPECIFICATION

COMPOSITION A-3, TYPE II (WITH POLYETHYLENE)

This specification is approved for use by the US Army Armament Research and Development Command, and is available for use by all Departments and Agencies of the Department of Defense.

1. SCOPE

1.1 This specification covers an explosive composition of RDX coated with polyethylene (See 6.1) which is designated as Composition A-3, Type II.

2. APPLICABLE DOCUMENTS

2.1 Issue of documents. The following documents of the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or request for proposal form a part of this specification to the extent specified herein.

SPECIFICATIONS

MILITARY

MIL-R-398	- RDX
MIL-E-63218	- Emulsion, Polyethylene
MIL-A-48078	- Ammunition, Standard Quality Assurance Provisions, General Specification For

STANDARDS

MILITARY

MIL-STD-105	- Sampling Procedures and Tables for Inspection by Attributes
MIL-STD-109	- Quality Assurance Terms and Definitions

FSC: 1376

Beneficial comments (recommendations, additions, deletions) and any pertinent data which may be of use in improving this document should be addressed to: Commander, US Army Armament Research and Development Command, Attn. DRDAR-QA, Dover, New Jersey 07801 by using the self-addressed Standardization Document Improvement Proposal (DD Form 1426) appearing at the end of this document or by letter.

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MIL-STD-650 - Explosives: Sampling, Inspection and Testing
MIL-STD-1168 - Lot Numbering of Ammunition
MIL-STD-1218 - ACS Chemicals
MIL-STD-1235 - Single and Multilevel Continuous Sampling Procedures and Tables for Inspection by Attributes

DRAWINGS

US ARMY

7548644 - Box, Packing for High Explosives, Assembly Details, Packing and Marking
7548645 - Box, Fiberboard, Packing, Reusable, Collapsible for High Explosives

(Copies of specifications, standards, drawings and publications, required by suppliers in connection with specific procurement functions should be obtained from the procuring activity or as directed by the contracting officer).

2.2 Publications. The following document forms a part of this specification to the extent specified herein. Unless otherwise indicated, the issue in effect on date of invitation for bids or request for proposal shall apply.

AMERICAN SOCIETY FOR TESTING AND MATERIALS PUBLICATION

ASTM Designation E300 - Recommended Practice for Sampling Industrial Chemicals
ASTM Designation D2905 - Statement on Number of Specimens Required to Determine the Average Quality of a Textile

(Application for copies of ASTM Standards should be addressed to the American Society for Testing and Materials, 1916 Race Street, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania 19103.)

(Technical society and technical association specifications and standards are generally available for reference from libraries. They are also distributed among technical groups and using Federal agencies.)

3. REQUIREMENTS

3.1 Material. Composition A-3, Type II shall consist of RDX crystals, complying with the requirements of MIL-R-398,

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Type II, coated with polyethylene, complying with the requirements of MIL-E-63218.

3.2 Composition. The composition shall be as follows when determined as specified in 4.5.1:

TABLE I. Composition of Type II Composition A-3

Ingredient	Composition
RDX, %	90.8 ± 0.9
Polyethylene, %	9.2 ± 0.9

3.3 Foreign matter. The finished composition shall be free of visible impurities and foreign matter, when examined as specified in 4.5.2.

3.4 Moisture. The moisture content of the composition shall not exceed 0.1 percent, when determined as specified in 4.5.3.

3.5 Acidity. The acid content, as acetic acid, shall not exceed 0.02 percent, when determined as specified in 4.5.4.

3.6 Insoluble particles. There shall be no insoluble particles retained on a United States (U.S.) Standard Number (No.) 40 sieve and not more than 5 insoluble particles retained on a U.S. Standard No. 60 sieve when determined as specified in 4.5.5.

3.7 Granulation. The composition shall comply with granulation requirements specified in Table II, when determined as specified in 4.5.6.

TABLE II. Granulation of Type II Composition A-3

Through U.S. Sieve No.	Percent	
	Min.	Max.
6	100	...
100	...	5

3.8 Bulk density. The minimum bulk density of the composition shall be 0.77 g/cc when determined as specified in 4.5.7.

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3.9 Sensitivity. The value obtained when the sample is tested in accordance with 4.5.8 shall not be less than 31cm.

3.10 Workmanship. The manufacturer shall employ procedures which provide controls that preclude conditions which may adversely affect the safety and reliability of the explosive (i.e., contaminated vessels, impurities, dirt, chips, etc.) Compliance with this paragraph shall be as specified in 4.5.9.

3.11 First article inspection. This specification contains technical provisions for the first article inspection. Requirements for the submission of first article samples by the contractor shall be as specified in the contract. (See 6.2)

4. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS

4.1 Responsibility for inspection. Unless otherwise specified in the contract or purchase order, the supplier is responsible for the performance of all inspection requirements as specified herein. Except as otherwise specified in the contract or order, the supplier may use his own or any Government approved facilities suitable for the performance of the inspection requirements specified herein. The Government reserves the right to perform any of the inspections set forth in the specification where such inspections are deemed necessary to assure supplies and services conform to the prescribed requirements. Reference shall be made to MIL-STD-109 to determine terms used herein.

4.2 Classification of inspections. The inspection requirements specified herein are classified as follows:

a. First article inspection (see 4.3)
b. Quality conformance inspection (see 4.4)
c. Packaging inspection (see 4.4.2 and 5)

4.3 First article inspection. (See 6.2)

4.3.1 Submission. The contractor shall submit a first article sample as designated by the Contracting Officer for evaluation in accordance with provisions of 4.3.2. The first article shall consist of ten (10) pounds (4.5 kg) of the composition obtained by sampling as described in 4.4.3.1. The samples shall be obtained from a production batch which has been produced by the contractor using the same production processes, procedures and equipment as will be used in

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fulfilling the contract. All materials shall be obtained from the same sources of supply as will be used in regular production.

4.3.2 Inspections to be performed. The sample will be subjected by the Government to any or all of the examinations or tests specified in Table III of this specification.

4.3.3 Rejection. See MIL-A-48078.

4.3.4 Process control. Submission of process controls to be utilized by the manufacturer to assure a quality product shall be made to the technical agency for review on all critical defects not subject to direct, discrete measurement and all major defects specifying sampling plans requiring fewer samples than the routine inspection levels of MIL-STD-105, or MIL-STD-1235.

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TABLE III. First article inspection

CLASSIFICATION OF DEFECTS & TESTS

PARAGRAPH	TITLE		SHEET 1 OF 1		DRAWING NUMBER / NEXT HIGHER ASSEMBLY
CATEGORY	EXAMINATION OR TEST	NO. OF SAMPLE UNITS	AQL OR 100%	REQUIREMENT PARAGRAPH	PARAGRAPH REFERENCE /INSPECTION METHOD
	Composition			3.2	4.5.1
	Foreign Matter			3.3	4.5.2
	Moisture			3.4	4.5.3
	Acidity			3.5	4.5.4
	Insoluble Particles			3.6	4.5.5
	Granulation			3.7	4.5.6
	Bulk Density			3.8	4.5.7
	Sensitivity			3.9	4.5.8
	Workmanship			3.10	4.5.9

NOTES:

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4.4 Quality conformance inspection.

4.4.1 Lot formation. A lot shall consist of one or more batches of Composition A-3, produced by one manufacturer, in accordance with the same specification, or same specification revision, under one continuous set of operating conditions. Each batch shall consist of that quantity of explosive that has been subjected to the same unit chemical or physical mixing process intended to make the final product homogeneous. In addition, each lot shall contain:

a. RDX, Type II, fropm one manufacturer only.
b. Polyethylene complying with the requirements of MIL-E-63218 from one interfix lot number, from one manufacturer only. The product shall be submitted for inspection in accordance with MIL-STD-105 unless otherwise specified. The criteria and procedures for the assignment of lot numbers shall be in accordance with MIL-STD-1168.

4.4.2 Examination. Unless otherwise specified in the Classification of Defects and test tables, sampling plans for major and minor defects shall be in accordance with MIL-STD-105, Inspection Level II (See MIL-A-48078).

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QUALITY CONFORMANCE INSPECTION

CLASSIFICATION OF DEFECTS & TESTS

MIL-C-63217 (AR)

PARAGRAPH	TITLE		SHEET 1 OF 1		DRAWING NUMBER 7548644/7548645
4.4.2.1	Wooden or fiberboard box				NEXT HIGHER ASSEMBLY
CATEGORY	EXAMINATION OR TEST	NO. OF SAMPLE UNITS	AQL OR 100%	REQUIREMENT PARAGRAPH	PARAGRAPH REFERENCE /INSPECTION METHOD
Critical	None defined				
Major					
101	Foreign matter		1.00		Visual
102	Liner pierced or torn		1.00		Visual
103	Liner improperly closed		1.00		Visual
Minor					
201	Type of liner incorrect		1.00		Visual

NOTES:

DRDAR-QA Form 160 Jul 77 Replaces SARPA-QA Form 2567 Feb 74 Which is Obsolete

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CLASSIFICATION OF DEFECTS & TESTS

PARAGRAPH	TITLE		SHEET 1 OF 1		DRAWING NUMBER
4.4.2.2	Sealed wooden box				7548644
					NEXT HIGHER ASSEMBLY
CATEGORY	EXAMINATION OR TEST	NO. OF SAMPLE UNITS	AQL OR 100%	REQUIREMENT PARAGRAPH	PARAGRAPH REFERENCE /INSPECTION METHOD
Critical	None defined				
Major					
101	Box damaged		1.50		Visual
102	Lot number incorrect or illegible		1.50		Visual
103	Board broken or split		1.50		Visual
104	Strapping missing broken or loose		1.50		Visual/Manual
105	Top improperly assembled		1.50		Visual/Manual
Minor					
201	Nail protruding		1.50		Visual
202	Marking incorrect or illegible		1.50		Visual
203	Strapping improperly assembled		1.50		Visual/Manual

NOTES:

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QUALITY CONFORMANCE INSPECTION

CLASSIFICATION OF DEFECTS & TESTS

MIL-C-63217 (AR)

PARAGRAPH	TITLE	SHEET	DRAWING NUMBER
4.4.2.3	Sealed fiberboard box	1 OF 1	7548645
			NEXT HIGHER ASSEMBLY

CATEGORY	EXAMINATION OR TEST	NO. OF SAMPLE UNITS	AQL OR 100%	REQUIREMENT PARAGRAPH	PARAGRAPH REFERENCE /INSPECTION METHOD
Critical	None defined				
Major					
101	Assembly torn or pierced		1.00		Visual
102	Lot number incorrect or illegible		1.00		Visual
103	Banding strips broken, missing or loose		1.00		Visual/Manual
Minor					
201	Marking incorrect or illegible		1.50		Visual
202	Stitches missing or loose (when required)		1.50		Visual/Manual
203	Banding strips improperly assembled		1.50		Visual/Manual

NOTES:

DRDAR-QA Form 160 Jul 77 Replaces SARPA-QA Form 2567 Feb 74 Which is Obsolete

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4.4.3 Testing.

PRECAUTION WARNING

This specification covers sampling and testing of toxic or hazardous materials. Accordingly, it is emphasized that all applicable safety rules, regulations and procedures must be followed in handling and processing these materials.

4.4.3.1 Sampling. Approximately 300 grams of the composition shall be selected from each batch to be sampled using ASTM Procedures E300 for solids. Samples shall be selected for inspection in accordance with MIL-STD-1235, CSP-1 Plan, Sample Frequency Code Letter B, AQL 6.5%. If any sample fails to meet any test requirement the batch represented by the sample shall be rejected. All batches produced between the last batch that was tested and accepted and the batch which failed shall be tested in accordance with the applicable methods given in paragraph 4.5. If any of these batches fail to meet any of the test requirements, that batch shall also be rejected. In addition, after any failure of a batch the contractor will return to 100% inspection until "i" successive batches are accepted as required by MIL-STD-1235. The defect classification shall be as given in Table IV.

TABLE IV.
CLASSIFICATION OF DEFECTS

Inspection/Requirement	Defect Classification
Composition (See 3.2)	Major
Foreign Matter (See 3.3)	Major
Moisture (See 3.4)	Major
Acidity (See 3.5)	Major
Insoluble Particles (See 3.6)	Major
Granulation (See 3.7)	Major
Bulk Density (See 3.8)	Major
Sensitivity (See 3.9)	Major
Workmanship (See 3.10)	Major

4.4.4 Inspection equipment. Commercially available inspection equipment should be used in the performance of all tests and examinations specified in 4.4 and 4.5. The contractor shall have the required equipment available, follow proper calibration methods and perform the testing in accordance with accepted operating procedures. Government approval of all inspection equipment is required prior to its use for acceptance purposes (see 6.3).

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4.5 Test methods and procedures (see 6.4). The following tests shall be performed using prescribed analytical procedures for replicate determinations given in standard analytical text books. ASTM method D2905 may also be used to determine the number of replicates required. Unless otherwise specified herein, all chemicals and reagents used in test methods shall be ACS grade in accordance with MIL-STD-1218 or reagent grade.

4.5.1 Determination of composition.

4.5.1.1 RDX content (see 6.4.1.1). A medium porosity glass filtering crucible shall be cleaned with hot aliphatic naphtha followed by a final rinse of acetone. The crucible shall be back filtered with acetone and be free flowing. The crucible shall be dried in a 100 ± 5°C oven for one hour, placed in a desiccator until cool and weighed to the nearest 0.0001g. An approximately 5g. portion of sample accurately weighed to the nearest 0.0001g shall be placed in a 150 ml beaker with a magnetic stirring bar, and 60 ml of aliphatic naphtha solvent added. The beaker shall be covered with a watch glass and placed on a magnetic stirrer hot plate (or equivalent) maintaining the temperature of the solution between 80 and 90°C and stirring for 30 minutes. The hot plate shall be checked for proper temperature by keeping on it a thermometer in a 400 ml beaker containing 100 ml of solvent. The top of the beaker shall be covered by aluminum foil and the solvent temperature shall be maintained within the specified range. During the filtration operation the previously prepared crucible and contents shall be kept at about 60-70°C. This is to prevent the polyethylene from coming out of solution and clogging the crucible. This may be accomplished by use of a safety approved heat gun or other commercially available equipment. The top of the solvent shall be decanted through the crucible and the RDX remaining in the beaker (and on the stirring bar) shall be washed with warm aliphatic naptha solvent and transferred quantitatively to the crucible using a wash bottle. No more than 40 ml of aliphatic naphtha solvent shall be used to effect the transfer. If necessary, rinse beaker with hexane to remove those RDX crystals that cling to sides of beaker. During filtration, the crucible shall not be aspirated dry until the final wash in order to prevent the polyethylene from freezing-out on the crucible. The crucible and contents shall be dried for 15 minute periods in a 90-105°C oven until constant weight within 0.0002g. is obtained. The percentage of RDX shall be calculated as follows:

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$$\text{Percent RDX} = \frac{100\ A}{W-(MW)}$$

Where:
A = increase in weight of filtering crucible, g.
W = weight of sample, g.
M = percent moisture in material, expressed as a decimal (See 4.5.3).

4.5.1.2 Densensitizer (See 6.4.1). The percentage of desensitizer shall be calculated on a moisture free basis by subtracting from 100 percent the percentage of RDX obtained as specified in 4.5.1.1.

4.5.2 Determination of foreign matter. Spread the sample taken in 4.4.3.1 on a white flat surface. Visually examine the material for foreign matter using daylight illumination to determine compliance with 3.3.

4.5.3 Determination of moisture content (See 6.4.1.2).

4.5.3.1 Special solvent. The special solvent shall consist of 80 parts methanol and 20 parts naphtha by volume thoroughly mixed. If necessary the solvents shall be dried by distillation.

4.5.3.2 Procedures (Karl Fisher Method). Determine the moisture content in accordance with Method 101.4.1 of MIL-STD-650.

4.5.4 Acidity. A 6g specimen shall be weighed accurately to the nearest 0.001g and transferred to a 400 ml beaker. A 25 ml portion of aliphatic naphtha shall be added and the beaker and contents covered with a watch glass and heated on a steam bath until the coating on the RDX crystals has completely dissolved. The aliphatic naphtha solution shall be decanted carefully into a clean small beaker, covered with a watch glass, and kept warm (above 40°C). Seventy-five ml of acetone shall be added to the RDX crystals remaining and the 400 ml beaker covered and heated on a steam bath until all of the crystals are in solution. The aliphatic naphtha solution shall be poured carefully back into the acetone solution and the small beaker washed thoroughly with about 5 ml of aliphatic naphtha, which shall also be added to the acetone solution. The beaker shall be heated gently while stirring to thoroughly mix the solution. Add 200 ml. of cool distilled water to the solution while continuing to stir. Remove the solution from the steam bath and titrate with 0.05N sodium hydroxide

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solution, using either methyl red or bromothymol blue as an indicator. A blank determination shall be made using the same amounts of the reagents. The percentage of acidity as acetic acid shall be calculated as follows:

$$\text{Percent acidity} = \frac{6.005\ (V-v)N}{W-(MW)}$$

Where:
V = ml sodium hydroxide used in titrating specimen.
v = ml sodium hydroxide used in blank.
N = normality of sodium hydroxide solution.
W = Weight of sample, g.
M = percent moisture in materials, expressed as a decimal (See 4.5.3).

4.5.5 Insoluble particles (See 6.4.1.4). Determine the insoluble particles in accordance with Method 106.1 of MIL-STD-650.

4.5.6 Granulation. Determine the granulation in accordance with Method 204.1 of MIL-STD-650.

4.5.7 Bulk density. Determine the bulk density in accordance with Method 201.1.1 of MIL-STD-650.

4.5.8 Sensitivity.

SAFETY PRECAUATIONS

Observe normal safety precautions. Pay particular attention to the following:

(1) Operate the exhaust fan while tests are being performed.

(2) Do not operate the machine without a safety shield.

(3) Secure the weight with a safety chain while cleaning the machine.

(4) Remove waste explosives from the room after completion of each test.

4.5.8.1 Apparatus. Impact machine (Naval Ordnance Drawing LD-70518), Sandpaper (No. 05, approximately 1 inch squares), 35 mg. loading spoon, wood or hard rubber spatula.

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4.5.8.2 Procedure. Pass a dry sample of the Composition A-3 through a sample splitter until a representative portion of approximately 10g is obtained. Proper safety should be exercised in determining the impact sensitivity of Composition A-3. Compliance with local safety rules is required. Position approximately 25 sandpaper squares with the sand side up on a flat surface. Fill the loading spoon with dry Composition A-3 and smooth off the excess by drawing a spatula across the flat surface of the spoon. Dump the remaining portion upon the center of one of the sandpaper squares. Repeat this procedure until all sandpaper blocks are loaded. Turn the exhaust fan switch to the "ON" position to remove dust and fumes from the area of the impact machine. Place the impact weight on the weight retainer. NOTE: Ascertain the anvil and plunger to be clean, free of scratches and cracks. Place one of the prepared samples on the center of the anvil. Insert the plunger through the guidehole above the anvil and allow the plunger to rest gently on the sample. Turn the electromagnet switch to the "ON" position. Lift the weight vertically until it is held in place by the electromagnet. Adjust the height of the weight by turning the gear handle to a height, that when dropped, will explode or burn the sample. Remove the weight retainer from the path of the weight. Facing away from the impact machine, turn the electromagnet switch to the "OFF" position, allowing the weight to fall and strike the top of the plunger. Lift the weight, replace the weight retainer and allow the weight to rest upon the retainer. Remove the plunger and determine if an explosion has occurred. Clean all unexploded material from the anvil, plunger, and base plate with a brush or cloth. NOTE: An explosion may be recognized by a sharp report, smoke in the area of the plunger or disintegration of the sample. Use of instrumented microphone with detectors is recommended. Once again place the impact weight on the weight retainer, place another prepared sample on the anvil and repeat the procedure, raising the electromagnet 5cm after each non-explosion and lowering the electromagnet 5cm after each explosion. The first non-explosion after an explosion is considered as the starting point of the 20 tests. Record this height in cm. Opposite the height recorded for the starting point, place a minus (-) sign designating a non-explosion. Raise the electromagnet 5cm and place the weight retainer in place and again repeat the procedure. If an explosion occurs, place a plus (+) sign opposite the height tested. If a non-explosion occurs, place a minus (-) sign. Raise or lower the electromagnet as required and repeat the procedure until 20 tests have been completed. Record each test result.

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Calculate the impact sensitivity as follows:

$$\text{Impact sensitivity, cm} = C - \left[\frac{5\ (D-50)}{D-E}\right]$$

Where C = The lowest height in cm at which more than 50% explosions occurred.
D = Percentage explosions greater than 50%
E = Percentage explosions less than 50%
5 = Difference in height in cm of each test

Example:

45 cm = 80% explosions
40 cm = 30% explosions
C = 45 cm
D = 80% explosions
E = 30% explosions
5 = 45 cm - 40 cm (difference)

Calculate the impact sensitivity as follows:

$$\text{Impact sensitivity, cm} = C - \left[\frac{5\ (80 - 50)}{80 - 30}\right]$$

$$= 45 - \left[\frac{5 \times 30}{50}\right]$$

$$= 45 - 3$$

Impact sensitivity = 42 cm

4.5.8.3 Interferences.

(1) A machine loosely assembled or not in proper alignment may produce incorrect values.

(2) A rough surface or cracks on the anvil or plunger may produce lower sensitivity values.

(3) Insufficient or unevenly distributed sample may produce incorrect values.

(4) A sample containing glass, metal or other gritty matter foreign to the product may produce low sensitivity values. (A low sensitivity valve indicates more sensitive material.)

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(5) Wet samples or samples containing oil, greases and soft plastics may produce high sensitivity values.

4.5.9 Workmanship. Visually examine the production of Comp A-3, Type II, and all samples submitted for testing.

5. PACKAGING

5.1 Packing.

5.1.1 Level A. Unless otherwise specified the Composition shall be packed in accordance with drawing 7548644.

5.1.2 Level B. (Level B to be used for CONUS shipment only.) Unless otherwise specified the Composition shall be packed in accordance with drawing 7548645.

5.2 Marking.

5.2.1 Level A. Marking shall be in accordance with drawing 7548644.

5.2.2 Level B. Marking shall be in accordance with drawing 7548645. The top and one side of the container shall also be marked "CONUS SHIPMENT ONLY" in addition to the other required marking.

6. NOTES

6.1 Intended use. The explosive composition covered by this specification is intended to be used as an alternate for Composition A-3 (MIL-C-440).

6.2 Ordering data. See MIL-A-48078 (PA).

6.3 Submission of inspection equipment designs for approval. See MIL-A-48078. Submit equipment designs, as required to Commander, ARRADCOM, ATTN: DRDAR-QAR, Dover, New Jersey 07801.

6.4 Equivalent test methods. Prior approval of the Contracting Officer is required for use of equivalent test methods. A description of the proposed method should be submitted though the Contracting Officer to: Commander, ARRADCOM, ATTN: DRDAR-QAR, Dover, New Jersey 07801. This description should include but not be limited to the procedures

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used, the accuracy and precision of the method, test data to demonstrate the accuracy and precision and drawings of any special equipment required.

6.4.1 Approved equivalent test methods. The following methods previously submitted by Holston Defense Corp are considered equivalent test methods.

6.4.1.1 RDX and desensitizer. HDC ASM No. C-36.

6.4.1.2 Moisture content. ASM No. I-7.

6.4.1.3 Sensitivity. ASM No. P-57 W/P-54.

6.4.1.4 Insoluble particles. ASM No. C-4.

Custodian:
Army-AR

Preparing Activity:
Army-AR

Project Number: 1376-A087

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